

The Bee Friendly Farming (BFF) certification program, funded as part of the FDF Extension and Adoption of Drought Resilience Farming Practices Grants program, and delivered by The Wheen Bee Foundation, protects and promotes pollinator health on agricultural lands. It provides guidelines and support for farmers and land managers to enhance pollinator habitats, improve food sources for bees and other pollinators, and implements integrated pest management strategies.

See how participants across Australia in the BFF certification program are benefiting from supporting pollinators, to enhance biodiversity on their properties and build drought and climate resilience into their farming businesses.

Bee Friendly Farming, OFI Almonds, Sunraysia growing region (Vic & NSW)

Samir Mecwan from OFI Almonds explains how the Bee Friendly Farming program helps this global leader in horticulture support its sustainable farming practices. Each year, OFI brings in 80,000 beehives to pollinate orchards across several properties in Victoria and NSW. Samir and the team ensure the bees are well looked after, with appropriate pollen and nectar resources, along with fresh water and permanent habitat.

29 July 2025

Introduction

This is the transcript of a video case study produced by the Wheen Bee Foundation, as part of their Bee Friendly Farming program in New South Wales and Victoria. The video is of Samir Mecwan from Olam Food Ingredients (OFI) explaining how the Bee Friendly Farming program helps support this global leader in its sustainable farming practices. Each year, OFI brings in 80,000 beehives to pollinate orchards across several properties in Victoria and NSW. Samir and the team ensure the bees are well looked after, with appropriate pollen and nectar resources, along with fresh water and permanent habitat. This project was funded by the Australian Government's Future Drought Fund as part of the Extension and Adoption of Drought Resilience Farming Practices Grants Program, and delivered by the Wheen Bee Foundation in partnership with Bee Friendly Farming

Learn more about the [Future Drought Fund](#), [Extension and Adoption of Drought Resilience Farming Practices Grants](#) and the [Wheen Bee Foundation](#).

Transcript

[Recording begins]

Samir Mecwan [0:12]

Hi this is Samir Mecwan. I am from OFI. We grow almonds on 15,000 hectares. We have other orchards in New South Wales and Victoria. The majority of our plantation is in Victoria and all the trees are almost 18 years old.

We need 80,000 beehives every year for pollination. OFI is a global leader in sustainable farming. We joined Bee Friendly Farming because it's a great contribution in improving overall environmental health. It is also helpful in attracting beekeepers who have an orchard because they will be assured that their bees will be taken care of. Bee Friendly Farming certification is helpful in our marketing of our product in international markets.

When bees are coming to our orchard, it's late winter and during that time there is very limited food source for them, so we ensure that they'll have enough food resource, pollen resource and nectar resource for them.

Every year, we plant annual bee forage for bees, and we have some native vegetation like this for bees to forage on. We are offering floral resources at least three per cent of our land. We are providing bloom off different flowering plants specifically during late winter and early spring.

Agriculture chemicals can be very toxic to bees. During pollination season, we do not spray any fungicide, we do not spray any herbicide. We prepare our orchards one month before the bee's arrival.

We are providing clean water access to bees. We have permanent bee habitat for other pollinators as well. So, for future plants we have some designated areas called Pollinator Resource. This area will be developed as permanent forage for bees and other pollinators. This area will have different plant species from trees, shrubs and ground covers. These tree species will provide bee forage throughout the year.

Bees are playing vital role in our food production to take pollen from one flower to another flower. It is such a simple process, but we need it. Without bees we cannot imagine crunching almonds.

Recording ends [3:15]

Bee Friendly Farming, Century Orchards

Century Orchards' Technical Manager, Gemma Nunn, explains how joining the Bee Friendly Farming program has strengthened the sustainability of their 700-ha almond and 100-ha pistachio operation in Loxton, South Australia. Each pollination season, the orchard welcomes around 4,000 hives—equating to approximately 6.5 hives per hectare—a density that reflects their commitment to optimal pollination. By adopting bee-friendly practices, Century Orchards has enhanced the health and productivity of its bees and its crops and built trust with commercial beekeepers.

3 July 2025

Introduction

This is the transcript of a video case study produced by the Wheen Bee Foundation, as part of their Bee Friendly Farming program in Loxton, South Australia. The video is of Gemma Nunn, Technical Manager at Century Orchards sharing how their large-scale almond and pistachio farm supports pollinator health through Bee Friendly Farming practices, including cover crops, native plantings, and dedicated water sources for bees. This project was funded by the Australian Government's Future

Drought Fund as part of the Extension and Adoption of Drought Resilience Farming Practices Grants Program and delivered by the Wheen Bee Foundation in partnership with Bee Friendly Farming.

Learn more about the [Future Drought Fund](#), [Extension and Adoption of Drought Resilience Farming Practices Grants](#) and the [Wheen Bee Foundation](#).

Transcript

[Recording begins]

Gemma Nunn [0:12]

Hi, I'm Gemma, I'm the Technical Manager here at Century Orchards.

Century is 700 hectares of almond plantings and 100 hectares of new pistachio plantings.

We were established in 1998, with our first plantings in 1999.

The almond pollination season takes place around August each year.

We would bring in approximately 4,000 hives over our 700-hectare property, which equates to about 6 and a half hives a hectare.

The reason we joined Bee Friendly Farming was because we wanted to ensure that all of our investors and other growers around us took the lead, it's really important that we do look after our pollinators and ensure that we can have something to show that we do.

Having a Bee Friendly Farming certification has really ensured that our business we can make sure that our almonds, when they're marketed moving forward, that we do have something to show for improving our pollinator health and making sure that we are looking after our bees.

It's super important, in that we can also show to our beekeepers what we are doing and making sure that our bees are looked after and that this is a happy place for them to come.

When our bees come onto site for pollination season it is crucial that we look after their health. This can include making sure that they've got water, so we actually run bee dripper emitters throughout our orchard, which are just stakes in the ground with an emitter on top of them, and we find that the bees actually like to soak that up.

We have included a cover crop throughout the year, which sort of consists of a number of different flowering species, that includes brassicas, barrel medics, vetch, a whole heap of different things and that sort of provides an extra pollen and nectar resource for our bees. The aim is, that will flower before, or during pollination, and that basically ensures that they do have that extra food source. You know... like you and me, I don't want a burger seven days a week for breakfast, lunch and dinner!

Our bees are really really important. We also have a number of native plantings on our property. These also include a range of different foraging material for bees. They range from gum trees all the way down to your shrubs and flowering cover crops, and that's also really important for the bees.

So, during our blossom, bees come in during August, they come in at night, and that's because they're sort of least active then, the next few days they all sort of roll in, and sort of start becoming more excited and you see them out in the blossoms. They love the white flower and how pristine everything is, it's really, really an important part of our business and probably my favourite time of the year.

Because we love our bees, we do want to look after them and we're wanting to become more sustainable and focussed on our pollinators and what they are doing and whether they're healthy or not, because ultimately the world relies on bees!

Recording ends [3:34]

Screen displays the text "For more information on ways you can make your farm more bee friendly, visit www.beefriendlyfarming.org.au"

End screen displays the text "The Bee Friendly Farming program received funding from the Australian Government's Future Drought Fund." The Australian Government logo and Future Drought Fund logo is displayed along with the Bee Friendly Farming logo and Wheen Bee Foundation logo.

Bee Friendly Farming, PHC Property Trust farm

Dr Chris Cannizzaro explains how the Bee Friendly Farming program helps him manage pollination on the 350-hectare macadamia orchard on the PHC Property Trust farm at Bundaberg in Queensland. The farm has a mix of managed bee hives and native bees, and Dr Cannizzaro is committed to building pollination efficiency through sustainable, productive ways to improve the drought and climate adaptation capacity of the business.

3 July 2025

Introduction

This is the transcript of a video case study produced by the Wheen Bee Foundation, as part of their Bee Friendly Farming program in Bundaberg in Queensland. The video is of Dr Chris Cannizzaro, Horticulturist at Macadamia Farm Management explaining how the Bee Friendly Farming program helps him manage pollination of a 350-hectare macadamia orchard on the PHC Property Trust farm. The farm has a mix of managed bee hives and native bees, and Dr Cannizzaro is committed to building pollination efficiency through sustainable, productive ways. This project was funded by the Australian Government's Future Drought Fund as part of the Extension and Adoption of Drought Resilience Farming Practices Grants Program and delivered by the Wheen Bee Foundation in partnership with Bee Friendly Farming.

Learn more about the [Future Drought Fund, Extension and Adoption of Drought Resilience Farming Practices Grants](#) and the [Wheen Bee Foundation](#).

Transcript

[Recording begins]

Dr Chris Cannizzaro [0:12]

G'day there, my name is Chris Cannizzaro, currently horticulturist at Macadamia Farm Management and we're here on the lovely PHC Property Trust farm here. We've got just about 350 odd hectares of macadamia trees, which is in excess of 100,000 individual beautiful macadamia trees here.

In terms of the number of hives that we bring onto the orchard, we essentially operate on a number of between two and five hives per hectare, and this essentially just ensures that we've got a reasonable amount of coverage and we're also actively placing those hives in certain spots so that we do get that coverage throughout the farm. Obviously, the more the better, but we do pay for the hives as well so that has to be costed into the account.

We're also looking to diversify our species of bees. So, here in Queensland we actually have native stingless bees, *Tetragonula* species, so we currently have those that we're breeding up to be distributed through different farms.

It's something we're really excited and passionate about, about bringing that native bee aspect in, in a managed way which is still able to be done commercially and then still maintaining a lot of that extra flora for the native bees.

For Macadamia Farm Management, one of the big reasons why we became involved with Bee Friendly Farming was to essentially get a bit of assistance in our IPM management just generally in the farm, but also because we inherently do have a strong belief in building pollination in a more natural and efficient way.

So, at Mac Farm Management, we've got several hundred stingless bee or native bee hives, and we wanted to incorporate that in a more sort of legitimate and official way.

Also, we were the recipients of several tree planting grants, which we're very fortunate to have. We take care of all the irrigation and all the mounding, and they contribute to the cost of the root stocks which we're able to plant and essentially extend that phenology, or that flowering, through the year, gives our bees a bit better access, builds them back up so that they're really strong for when our flowers come on. Little bits of flower are okay throughout the year but it's not too natural when you've got monocultures where there's just an explosion of flowers.

How Bee Friendly Farming helps our business is largely through the certification. So, we're looking to be more responsible, sustainable farmers in a climate where essentially your longevity depends on it and also the consumer is really looking for it. We want to be in line with responsible practice and producers of really the only native crop that Australia has so we feel also a responsibility to make sure that we're doing our best to bring Australia a good, clean, healthy crop and also Bee Friendly Farming has professionals that sort of consult with us and help us with IPM questions that we have throughout the season.

Some of the issues that we need to be aware of in terms of bee health, they obviously need to be maintained and kept in Australia, especially in central Queensland where we're in a warm climate. They're not going to go to sleep like in Europe over the winter and have a long holiday. They're pumping and they're working and they're creating brood all year, so we need to make sure that they've got food, we need to make sure that they've got water, we need to make sure they're free of disease.

Things that we've done to make our farms particularly more bee friendly are the bee friendly flora plantings, we have also set aside areas specifically for bee flora, so our dams have short surrounds that have bits of native remnant bush, we also have creek lines that line our farm as well. So, bees need access to water, they need that consistently, they also need access to a diversity of food, it can't just be a gigantic pulse of macadamia, they need a bit of diversity in their diets, so we will be continuing to plant more bee friendly flora along our fence lines and places where we're not particularly being productive.

The steps that we take to support bee health and safety really, on our farm, is we're trying to place those hives in areas that are going to be unaffected by equipment, machinery, getting dust sort of blown all over them and that sort of thing. We're also trying to be aware of other apiarists in the area, because bees can sort of spread disease between different colonies, but for the most part it's just ensuring that those bees aren't exposed to any harmful pesticides or chemicals.

Talking with our neighbours. A lot of times maybe we're not particularly spraying anything that's harmful to a bee, but we adjoin certain areas where they might be growing fruits and vegetables, and those chemistries can be particularly harmful to insects so just making sure we're talking with our neighbours and everyone else and keeping them safe.

Moving forward, we really want to bolster up those tree lines with not only bee friendly flora but flora that supports other pollinators - beneficial wasps, certain species that will eat the nasty bugs that we don't want. We're trying to look more broadly and just think about pollinators in general. So that's going to include our native bees, our stingless bees. There's a lot of native bees in Queensland as well that just occur naturally throughout this area, so we want our blue banded bees, our reed bees, our carpenter bees, our syrphid flies, to just be in the area naturally, and of course the more diversity that you have access to, the better off you'll be. Because, as soon as those nodes snap, if you're relying on one, it's all gone.

So, in the future we want to be diverse, productive, safe and give Australia the nuts they want.

Recording ends [6:18]

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Bee Friendly Farming, Bangadang Farm

Bangadang Farm Manager Katie discusses her involvement in the Bee Friendly Farming program, detailing how bees are vital to the pollination of their produce and the holistic nature of the business, a 345-hectare farm that grows a wide range of fruits in Donnybrook, Western Australia. Learn about the new changes and infrastructure Katie and her team have added to the property including planting more trees, cutting down chemical use and undertaking reforestation projects, and why this is important to improve their farm business.

29 July 2025

Introduction

This is the transcript of a video case study produced by the Wheen Bee Foundation, as part of their Bee Friendly Farming program in Donnybrook, Western Australia. The video is of Bangadang Farm Manager Katie, discussing their involvement in the Bee Friendly Farming program and the new changes and infrastructure Katie and her team have added to the property which include planting more trees, cutting down on chemical use and undertaking reforestation projects. This project was funded by the Australian Government's Future Drought Fund as part of the Extension and Adoption of Drought Resilience Farming Practices Grants Program and delivered by the Wheen Bee Foundation in partnership with Bee Friendly Farming.

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Transcript

[Recording begins]

Katie [0:12]

Hi, I'm Katie and I work on Bangadang farm, here in a beautiful part of Donnybrook. We have here on the farm 345 hectares of mainly pasture. Before the current family took over the farm, it was predominately cattle rearing, so it was really barren landscape and today we have seven and a half hectares worth of avocados and we have developed in the heart of the farm, a two and a half hectare food forest where we grow a numerous amount of stone fruit, citrus, different types of vegetables, pomegranate: everything that you can possibly imagine that can possibly grow in this part of WA, we are trying here.

And so, one of the things we have produced from the food forest this year is an abundance of lemons and we're working within the local community, to collaborate and create our own limoncello and things like that.

We're just trying to create an abundance of goodness from this fruit bowl area of Western Australia. We're heading into stone fruit season now and we're looking at how we can best utilise that as well.

So, when the family who currently own Bangadang took over seven years ago, it was a real passion

of theirs, honey particularly, they loved honey, we put it on everything that we eat and there is no denying now how important bees are to our society and our environment. So, it was one of their passion projects really early on to get into that.

We're conscious of the ways that bees can help us across the farm and the holistic nature of our farm and how we want to incorporate everything into it from the water to the bees, to the land and the soil, this is so important, and the bees help us with that so that's why we joined Bee Friendly Farming.

So, the bees and the hives help in a variety of ways across the farm, but particularly they help with the pollination down at the avocados and across our food forest. In addition, the bees and the hives are our business in many ways, we're working on producing honey and creating our own Bangadang honey here on the farm.

So, here at Bangadang we've done a lot of things to make our property more bee friendly. Not only have we planted our food forest, which is obviously the hub for our hives, but also, we've taken on reforestation and conservation projects across the farm which are good for native and wild bees as well.

We're not only focusing on our hives but also the wider region and how that can help surrounding orchards. Here on the farm, we love purple and one of the ways we've made ourselves more bee friendly is by planting a lot of the foliage and plants across the farm that flower with a purple flower, which obviously the bees love as well. Things like lavender, the artichoke we let the heads stay on we don't harvest that we let the bees forage from there, native wisteria, and other plants across the farm that we just leave to the last minute to cut so that the bees get the full nutrition from them that they can.

So, here on the farm we're always making new changes and adding to the infrastructure and the environment of the farm. One of the ways that we've done this is by planting 1000 new trees over the last couple of months and we're excited for what this is going to do for our farm, not only aesthetically, but for the bees and for insects across the board.

One of the other things that we've done recently is establish our own nursery, a nursery that is just predominantly for our farm here. What we've done is planted around 500 trees, mostly Marri, a couple of eucalypts and tea tree but mostly Marri, which the bees absolutely love. So, what we're planning on doing is using these trees to replant some of the bare paddocks and that basically is going to support the bees not only on the farm but also wild bees across Western Australia.

There's no denying that Bangadang farm would not be as beautiful as it is today without our bees and we're very grateful for everything that they do for us.

Recording ends [4:05]

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Bee Friendly Farming, Down2Earth Gardening

As part of the Bee Friendly Farming program, Down2Earth Gardening is always improving their edible and bee friendly farm in Carup, Western Australia. To grow the native bee population in their garden, they have something flowering throughout the year, plant a variety of crops, avoid chemicals and utilise ponds to ensure pollinators are hydrated in dry and hot conditions. Hear about their journey to become more bee friendly and about their work educating others on the importance of pollinators and how to support them.

29 July 2025

Introduction

This is the transcript of a video case study produced by the Wheen Bee Foundation, as part of their Bee Friendly Farming program in Carup, Western Australia. The video is of Julie and Garry Richards from Down2Earth Gardening, share how they've transformed their property into a pesticide-free, pollinator-friendly garden through their involvement with the Bee Friendly Program. They also run educational workshops and advocate for urban pollinator gardens to boost local food production and biodiversity. This project was funded by the Australian Government's Future Drought Fund as part of the Extension and Adoption of Drought Resilience Farming Practices Grants Program, and delivered by the Wheen Bee Foundation in partnership with Bee Friendly Farming.

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Transcript

[Recording begins]

Julie [0:11]

Hello, I'm Julie and this is Garry (Hi) and we're from Down2Earth Gardening here in Cardup, just south of Perth. We've purchased the property seven years ago and we've been living here for six and a half years. It's half an acre, we use about half of that for production with food, beneficial plants, bee hives. We promote healthy gardening using no pesticides, no herbicides.

Gary [0:48]

Pollinator friendly gardening.

Julie [0:50]

We grow seedlings to sell, we also grow a lot of plants and save the seeds, and we sell the seeds as well.

Gary [1:01]

We don't bring any beehives on they're all static, we have 15 European beehives, but we also have created spaces for native bees. So, our bees are used predominantly for pollination in the garden to improve our yield but also improve our friends yields, our neighbours yields.

Julie [1:23]

So, we do a lot of bee friendly workshops, and we call them Bee Adventures, so people come who are thinking about getting into bee hives and they come and do an hour, hour and a half with Gary out there, have a bit of fun, have a few giggles and get into a hive.

Gary [1:39]

Yeah, we don't keep bee hives just for honey, we use it for pollination.

Julie [1:44]

And it's become addictive because we said we were only going to have a couple of hives, so we got one, then that became two, three, four and now there's 15...

Gary [1:55]

But, then there's another 10 elsewhere on other people's properties to help them with their pollination.

Julie [2:00]

We joined Bee Friendly Farming because one, to give us a little bit of kudos for what we're doing because we're really proud of what we're doing here and what we've achieved but also its given us another string to our bow when we're doing workshops and when we're doing markets and festivals, because we can tell people more about the benefits of having a bee friendly garden. It's not just about the vegetables, it's also about the plants, the flowers, the pollination, that they're going to get and also just encouraging 'bee friendly'.

Gary [2:35]

I didn't know that 90% of our bees actually burrow underground, so we've started to generate an environment where our native bees can have somewhere to live. So, working in conjunction with the European Bee, the native bee, they come together in the garden because we create that environment and the Bee Friendly Farming organisation and the Wheen Bee Foundation actually support our role in the whole country, it's great.

Julie [3:06]

Our neighbours have also benefited because by speaking to a lot of neighbours they're getting better production in their gardens from flowers and fruits trees by us doing this Bee Friendly gardening.

We've made our property more bee friendly after being here for six and a half years, we don't disturb the soil as much as we did in the past at other places. We plant as much as we can diversity, so every time I plant vegetables, I'm planting a flower of some sort. We always make sure that in our garden all throughout the year, all different seasons, there's always something flowering, so we've got to learn a lot about the native flowers to this particular area, so that we can see what's flowering, what's not and we try to encourage that don't we?

Gary [3:59]

Yeah, we use no dig, we don't like, we got rid of the till method - apart for my bad back - but we also discovered there's lots of empirical evidence that suggests you're better off just using no dig actually. Yields are good, we interplant, we don't go mono crop, we go multi-planting. We just don't use any chemicals, we don't use any chemical fertilisers, we use compost.

Julie [4:29]

We call this place an edible, liveable garden, that's our excuse for actually leaving the weeds (Gary - or for being very lazy) but weeds are good (Gary - yeah weeds are good.)

We've made the steps of actually installing four ponds in the garden, three you wouldn't even know are there just little small ones and one larger one so that the bees have always got a water source throughout the year and they seem happy they're always they're calm.

Gary [4:58]

Yeah - it depends on how I behave, if I don't sing to them right –

Julie [4:59]

Gary's got a habit of singing Kate Bush to the bees (Gary - I really do like Kate Bush cause they like the key of C), he goes out with a cup of tea, cause they do like the key of c, but I can't sing cause I'm tone deaf so I don't go and sing to the bees but Gary does don't you?

So, it's water, plenty of forage and a bit of Kate Bush (Gary - and a bit of Kate Bush).

Gary [5:19]

I really want to see more food and more pollination friendly gardens in the urban settings, so I want to see, pollinator friendly gardens, in our cities, growing more food, because we need to grow about 30 per cent of our food in our cities to help with logistics cause they help with the environment, so the more and more we can do, to show, bring people and show them what you can do, and you can actually do it in a relatively small space you don't need half an acre you only need a couple of hundred square metres and you can do it.

Julie [5:54]

And you can do it even smaller anyway, everyone can help

Gary [5:56]

Yeah, you can do it on a balcony as well couldn't you. (Julie – yep)

Julie [6:00]

We're open to teaching and talking to people about it

Gary [6:03]

And learning more always learning more

Julie [6:05]

Yeah, we're always learning all the time.

Gary [6:12]

Is it teatime yet?

Recording ends [6:26]

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Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/about/news/supporting-pollinators-to-strengthen-ag>